

MYTHIC MODERNISM
'Goddess', acrylic on canvas, 2023

60 in, 2023), the buffalo-demon Mahishasura is represented as two separate beings, a buffalo and a horned man, as though his soul has been bifurcated by the goddess's fiery gaze. Other works like 'Kaliyadaman', too, are deeply informed by the way people internalise mythologies.

Parekh also says that, while she is wary of transposing post-facto meanings onto her paintings, over the years, she has cultivated a certain detachment that kicks in once she stops the work. "My attachment to the drawing is only till the point I am still working on it," she says. "Once the work is done, I don't mind too much what someone's opinion is. Now it is up to you to make up your mind about the work; what meaning you find there is your choice." ■

—Aditya Mani Jha

Glass Palace

SHEESH MAHAL, A MEDIEVAL HERITAGE STRUCTURE IN DELHI'S SHALIMAR BAGH, HAS REOPENED TO THE PUBLIC AFTER A RECENT RESTORATION

It was once a Mughal royal retreat set in a typical charbagh-style garden with fountains and water channels. Then it fell into disrepair following decades of neglect. Now, after a meticulous restoration by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) in association with the Delhi Development Authority (DDA), Sheesh Mahal has regained a modicum of its former glory and has been opened to the public.

The latest restoration push came from Delhi's lieutenant governor Vinai Kumar Saxena. "On a visit to the site in January last year, I took serious note of the Bagh's deplorable, dilapidated and crumbling condition and the urgent need to preserve this priceless piece of our heritage," he wrote on X on July 2, the day the restored structure was inaugurated.

Shah Jahan built the Sheesh Mahal for his third wife, Izz-un-Nissa Begum, in 1653. Standing on a high plinth and featuring *lakhori* brick masonry walls, it has an impressive central hall and a central circular archway flanked on either side by three cusped arch openings resting on fluted columns. Set in West Delhi's Shalimar Bagh garden, Sheesh Mahal was the setting for Aurangzeb's preliminary coronation in 1658, when it was known as Aizzabad Bagh. David Ochterlony, who served as the British resident to the Mughal court in the early 19th century, is said to have used the Sheesh Mahal as a summer retreat. While the restoration of the main structure is complete, the fountains and the garden are still a work in progress. ■

—Amit Dixit



The restored Sheesh Mahal unveiled at Shalimar Bagh, Delhi

HARDIK CHHABRA

SET IN SHALIMAR BAGH GARDEN, SHEESH MAHAL WAS THE SETTING FOR AURANGZEB'S PRELIMINARY CORONATION IN 1658